



HOPE & GLORY

ESSAYS ON THE LEGACY OF THE



54TH MASSACHUSETTS REGIMENT

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“THEIR TIME WILL YET COME”

The African American Presence in Civil War Reenactment

As the sun rose on May 31, the camp began to stir. The cooks built up crackling hardwood fires, and fresh coffee became the first thing in every soldier's mind. The men happily visited the cookhouse for a warm cup, instead of using the precious ration each one jealously carried in his haversack.

The major was up with cup in hand to greet the men. “Good morning, lads,” he said. “Well, this is the day we’ve been planning for two years. I want to thank you for being here, for traveling so far to be in Boston.”

The sergeant major, saluting the major, handed him the morning reports. “Sir!” he barked. “All of the companies have reported, sir.”

Just over a mile away at the State House, work crews finished the last details of the platform where the dignitaries would review the troops and address the crowds. The platform, so tall that men had to climb into the trees and tie back the branches, commanded the corner of Park and Beacon Streets. Anxious cleaning and polishing left the parade route and Boston Common sparkling.

At nine o'clock the regimental adjutant carried the national colors to the center of the parade ground in the middle of the encampment. The first sergeants gave the call to fall in. As each company formed and marched into place, the colors moved to the center. After a flawless inspection and drill, the major gave the last instructions for the day. “Men, you see around you the largest body of black soldiers yet assembled. We are all here for one reason: to remember those brave men that history has all but forgotten. It is your commitment and pride that everyone will see.”

The march to the State House began at Park Square, where the regiment formed, turned right, and stepped off. It proceeded through the downtown business district, and when it turned onto Washington Street, the thunder of drums froze shoppers in place as rank after rank of soldiers passed. Filled with pride and a sense of mission, the blue-clad columns of men advanced past City Hall and turned onto Trem-

ont Street. Once on Tremont, the major sent back the order to look sharp. Now the time had come. The color sergeants unfurled the flags in the brisk, warm breeze. Spotless brass glittered in the sun. The men pulled and straightened their equipment as the officers dressed the ranks.

From the start, the major had been at the head of the column. It seemed strange to him that a white man should lead this martial parade of black soldiers. Yet he knew that he had the trust of the men and that he would not let them down. "Lord," he said, "so much planning, so much work. Please let me do what I need to do." Turning back, he looked at the long blue lines. "What a sight!" he thought. "I am so fortunate to be here."

As the regiment resumed its march up Park Street toward Beacon, the major could see that both sides of the street and the expanse of lawn before the State House had filled with people. "Head of the column to the left!" he called, and the men of the Fifty-fourth Massachusetts Volunteer Infantry turned the corner in front of the State House. The crowd drew one long breath and then broke into cheers.

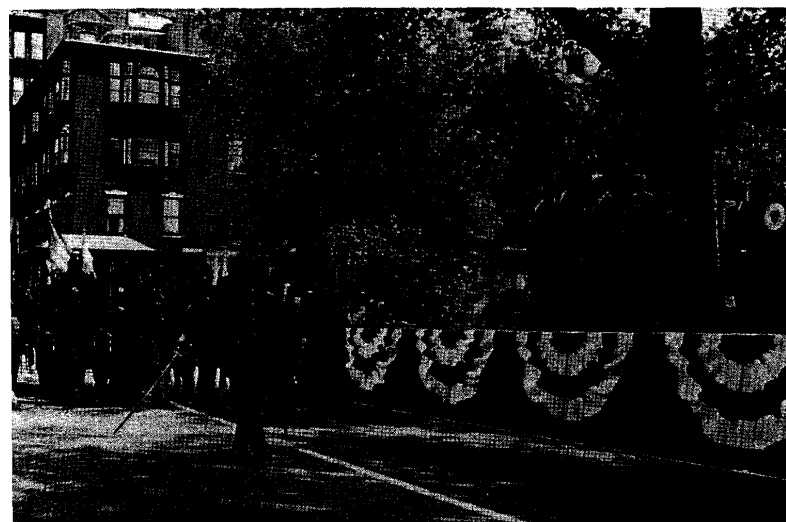
The officers of the regiment, swords drawn, saluted the dignitaries as they passed the platform. The soldiers, ramrod straight, marched on. Following close behind, a column of cavalry tightened their formation, their horses straining at the bit. The black cavalrymen sat proudly in their saddles, sabers at the ready.

The soldiers moved into the small space in front of the platform. This would be the test of whether the men had mastered the drill. Each company commander gave the order "Countermarch by files left," and the battalion turned and doubled back. The swelling crowd had pushed into the street, leaving less room than the major had anticipated. He knew the formation needed every foot of space. "Just a few more feet," he thought. As he gave the order "Battalion, halt!" 150 pairs of leather brogans took a last step in unison. "Front, order arms, parade rest!" The men pivoted their muskets to the left; officers dropped the points of their swords, and all was quiet.

Time had come full circle. Before the platform stood two hundred men and women in nineteenth-century military and civilian dress, juxtaposed with the twentieth-century dignitaries. Behind the platform loomed the timeless Saint-Gaudens bronze image of the Fifty-fourth's black soldiers and their young colonel, who had marched through these very streets more than 130 years earlier.¹

IN RECENT years, historical reenactors have become a familiar feature on the commemorative landscape. Yet their motives baffle many who encounter them. Why, spectators often wonder, would anyone want to relive anything as agonizing as the American Civil War—or any war? What prompts reenactors' sometimes fanatical devotion to "authenticity?" What happens when reenactment touches on still unresolved tensions over regionalism, gender roles, and, of course, race? Why do black reenactors choose to revisit an era when blacks' claims to citizenship and even humanity were rejected by most white Americans? This essay addresses the questions of motivation, identity, and interpretation raised by the African American presence in the Civil War reenactor community.

In adopting Civil War personas, black reenactors, like their historical models in the Fifty-fourth Massachusetts Regiment and elsewhere, enter a field originally claimed by and for whites. They play their Civil War roles only temporarily: the war always ends when the weekend is over. But their reenactment experiences can tell us a great deal about the present state of race relations in America. We explore here how the



Troops passing in review before General Powell at the monument to Shaw and the Fifty-fourth, 1997. Courtesy National Park Service.

black minority's experience of reenactment compares with the white majority's and consider the phenomenon of reenactment as a complex response to the many social changes of the past half-century. Although our central focus is on questions of race, this study of African Americans in reenactment also reveals more general contemporary patterns in Americans' changing relationship to their past.

ROOTS OF REENACTMENT

Although modern Civil War reenactment has developed only since the Civil War centennial of the 1960s, amateur performers have represented the war in different ways ever since the guns stopped firing. Scholars of this type of cultural performance have shown that, far from being mere reflections of "real-life" circumstances, these performances constitute dynamic moments when social relationships are negotiated and renegotiated, often with significant consequences for the cultures that produce them.² The various forms of Civil War reenactment, then, can reveal a great deal about changing views of the war and changing American social conditions.

The first "reenactments" of the Civil War were by the veterans themselves, and the first such large-scale public performance was the Grand Review in Washington, D.C., in May 1865, marking the Union victory. At this two-day parade of Union regiments, federal officials continued their wartime discrimination against black regiments, excluding them from participation. The few blacks who were included were either presented as little more than laborers or as individuals exploited for comic relief. As Stuart McConnell reports, "Two large black soldiers . . . for example, were displayed 'riding on very small mules, their feet nearly touching the ground.'" "Contraband" (escaped slaves) included in the Grand Review were dressed in outlandish clothes, many also riding mules. Some observers commented on the absence of the black units, and one journalist with the *Philadelphia Inquirer* concluded that "by some process it was arranged that none of them should be here. . . . They can afford to wait. Their time will yet come."³

That time did not come in the remaining years of the nineteenth century, the period of the veterans' greatest activity in commemorating the war. Some radical members of the Grand Army of the Republic (GAR), the leading association of Union veterans, did advocate for the rights of black veterans within the organization, and activists like Frederick Douglass spoke occasionally at GAR encampments and meetings. But nearly all GAR posts were segregated by race, and black veterans who applied to white posts for membership were routinely rejected.

As one study of the GAR observed, "the same wave of reconciliation sentiment that was inspiring Blue-Gray reunions and Confederate veterans' homes in 1890 was also heightening GAR ambivalence about race relations." Veterans who regarded a thorough reconstruction of the South and black suffrage as their wartime legacy did not feel obliged to support "social equality" in the North. Although many supported some version of political equality, most still adhered to the color line outside of politics.⁴

Many white veterans in the North and South believed that the social upheavals of the late nineteenth century threatened the values they had fought for in the war. The strongly conservative, nativist flavor of all veterans' activities—Union and Confederate—overwhelmed any lingering sectional tensions. In this atmosphere, black challenges from within their own organizations were particularly unwelcome to white veterans.

Nonetheless, discussion of race did find its way into veterans' activities. A heated debate over whether segregated posts should be official policy dominated the 1891 GAR national encampment. The color line continued to be upheld in practice although disclaimed officially. But the issue attracted national attention and caused an unusual airing of differing views on race within the GAR. One of those views, which would reappear among modern black and white reenactors, centered on the belief that shared military service could supersede racial divisions. Insisting that veterans should not adopt the segregation prevalent in churches, schools, and other fraternal organizations, former GAR commander William Warner maintained that these "are matters of sociability. Comrades, when these black or white men, or whatever color or nationality they may have been, shouldered the musket in defense of the Union, it was not a question of etiquette, a question of sociability. It was a question of patriotism and loyalty." But such social change was more symbolic than actual. Blacks remained on the fringes of official white veterans' activities. Moreover, their presence in the historical record of the Civil War continued to be provocative and troubling for many whites who sought to portray the war through commemoration and performance.⁵

PAGEANTS

Unease over race was also evident in American pageantry, a hugely popular form of public performance in the first two decades of the twentieth century. Historical pageants often featured episodes that linked local and national histories and tended to reflect many Americans'

buoyant belief in progress. Although the Civil War was a frequent subject in pageant scenes, battle recreations were less common than vignettes of camp or home-front life. Rarer still were episodes dealing with the causes of the war or with black Americans' role in it. There were exceptions. A 1913 pageant in Newburyport, Massachusetts, featured four floats devoted to African American and abolitionist history. A Springfield, Massachusetts, pageant of 1908 included black Civil War veterans reenacting the assault on Battery Wagner. One observer speculated that the pageant revealed a "glimpse of America of the future which is to come out of this mingling of races and race-ideals."⁶

But this optimistic assessment of the American melting pot would not be successfully sustained. Many white pageant organizers, whether liberal or conservative, remained ambivalent about racial equality or disheartened by the failed promises of emancipation and Reconstruction. Like the organizers of the Grand Review in 1865, most pageant organizers found it easier to rely on stock comic black figures in pageants or to ignore African Americans completely. The result, clearly, was to widen the gap between black and white life in America. The gigantic 1914 pageant celebrating Saint Louis's 150th anniversary, for example, "sharpened the differences between black and white residents" and contributed to the adoption of legal segregation in the city two years later.⁷

Some black performers and organizers responded to blacks' virtual exclusion from social or popular pageantry by orchestrating their own pageants. W.E.B. Du Bois, contending that "the American Pageant Association has been silent, if not actually contemptuous, of efforts to use pageantry as black folk drama," wrote and directed "The Star of Ethiopia," a black history pageant that premiered in 1913 as part of the NAACP's celebration of the fiftieth anniversary of the Emancipation Proclamation. But this event was also an exception. In general, pageantry remained a white form of cultural expression that ignored African Americans and helped erase the black contribution to American history from popular white consciousness.⁸

CONTEMPORARY REENACTMENT

The same racial cultural patterns held true for the modern phenomenon of Civil War reenactment, which originated in the "heritage phenomenon" following World War II.⁹ Civil War roundtables, battlefield tourism, and black powder weapons clubs all gained popularity during this period when many middle-class Americans became historical pilgrims in search of some authentic sense of connection with the nation's past.

The Civil War centennial in 1961–65 was the catalyst for a new kind of cultural performance. Wearing makeshift Civil War uniforms, enthusiastic amateur performers (including National Guardsmen and members of black powder clubs such as the North-South Skirmish Association) joined to recreate Civil War battles. Despite the official disapproval of the National Park Service, which expressed concern over safety and historical accuracy, and a tapering off of interest after the Civil War centennial, the nucleus of a Civil War reenactment community formed in those years.

Activity within this community remained sporadic during the next decade. Few Americans could find pleasure in mock battles while the nation fought a costly and troubling real war in Vietnam. Not until after the Vietnam era did interest in recreational reenactment revive, and then the Revolutionary War bicentennial, not the Civil War, provided the focus. During the bicentennial years of 1976–81, experienced reenactors were joined by younger men, who had come of age after World War II. That important generational shift has, to a large extent, shaped contemporary reenactment.

As in the Civil War centennial, the younger generation of reenactors was almost entirely male and white. One author of this essay, who joined the reenactment community in the 1970s, recalls encountering only one bicentennial-era black reenactor, a man who portrayed a freedman in a British infantry regiment. Ethnic and feminist challenges to traditional versions of American history had not fully penetrated popular American historical consciousness, and reenactors still presented the past as a tale of white men's deeds.

With the end of the bicentennial in 1981, many reenactors turned their attention to the Civil War. Most of the structures and practices of the Civil War reenacting community developed during the cycle of large battle reenactments staged to commemorate the 125th anniversary of the war in 1986–91. Civil War encampments are now staged across the country (and also outside it) throughout the year, with reenactor attendance ranging from two or three people to more than ten thousand. Some events are organized by reenactors; for others, they are recruited and sometimes paid a fee by event organizers, which often include historical societies or other civic groups. Film producers, schools, and museums also increasingly make use of reenactors' unique form of "edutainment" in their own presentations of history.¹⁰

The Influence of *Glory*

Although Civil War reenactment remains primarily a white male activity, the 1990s saw significant changes in the reenactor population.

Women, in both combat and noncombatant roles, have added female perspectives to the depictions of Civil War reenactments. Since the popularizing of the story of the Fifty-fourth Massachusetts in the 1989 film *Glory*, black reenactors have joined the reenactment community in increasing numbers. Just as the mobilization of black soldiers late in the Civil War sparked a critical national discussion of race, the recent presence of blacks in the reenactor community has drawn attention to a dimension of the Civil War story that many white reenactors have minimized: the role of race and racism in the conflict.

The African American presence in Civil War reenacting emerged almost entirely from the making of *Glory*. Like the makers of previous Civil War movies, the film's producers recruited a number of white reenactors to serve as skilled extras. But since nearly no experienced black reenactors existed at that time, film producers raised four companies to portray the enlisted men of the Fifty-fourth Massachusetts.¹¹ Just as the Civil War centennial gave birth to modern reenactment, *Glory* became the driving force for a distinctly African American element in reenacting.

Currently, five companies of the Fifty-fourth Massachusetts Regiment have been organized, joined by about ten companies of other black Civil War-era units. The meeting of past and present creates an unusual internal dynamic in these units. Until very late in the Civil War, no black commissioned officers existed in the Union army. But in today's black reenactment regiments, African Americans have assumed leadership both in founding and running the organizations. This result is a dual level of leadership in which white "officers" take charge on stage but have either equal or subordinate roles when the units are offstage. This dual leadership—performative and administrative—often operates in white units as well. The factor of race, however, makes it a necessity in African American units, requiring all members of these groups to accept the paradox of "followers" who lead and "leaders" who must follow.

It is important to emphasize that the "integration" of the reenactor community takes place in varying degrees and at different levels. Both black and white reenactors find their most intense experiences of camaraderie within their own units. This fact, along with the historical separation of black and white regiments, means that blacks and whites may camp near one another at reenactments and take to the field at the same time, but they experience little interchange on the field. At small, low-key events, there may be more intermingling, even to the extent of black and white reenactors "fighting" side by side, in defiance of historical precedent.¹² At larger or more tightly scripted events, historical



Civilian reenactors at the Centennial Celebration of the monument to Shaw and the Fifty-fourth, 1997. Courtesy National Park Service.

conventions are usually more closely observed, for reasons of both accuracy and preference. For instance, at the annual February reenactment of Florida's Battle of Olustee, where the Fifty-fourth Massachusetts and the Eighth U.S. Colored Troops played critical roles, large numbers of black reenactors participate. They camp together to follow the historical model and have become more closely acquainted over the years as a result. In all cases, "integration" is complicated by the need to simulate nineteenth-century race relations and by the tendency of the closest reenactor relationships (as in the military) to form within units rather than between members of different units.

Striving for historical accuracy creates additional challenges and new opportunities for contemporary reenactors. A small number of reenactors portray both slaves and free blacks who fought for the Confederacy; another handful are beginning to choose roles as "contraband" or other civilians. As with white reenactor groups, women in black units are finding new roles. In Boston's Company A of the Fifty-fourth Massachusetts, a group of women organized originally during the Shaw/Fifty-fourth Centennial Celebration now reenact as the Colored Ladies' Baptist Relief Society. During the 1997 event, the two hundred black Civil War reenactors from around the country who encamped at Charlesbank Park on Boston's Charles River Esplanade represented about 85 percent of all black reenactors in the United States. The gathering led to new discussions about the broader organization of black units within the Civil War reenactment community. It is precisely this point—black reenactors' search for a place within the larger Civil War community and the country's historical consciousness—that reveals some of the most important findings of this study and helps illuminate the ways in which Americans continue to struggle with the legacy of the Civil War.

Perceptions of the Past and Present

Before the 1960s American history was generally taught and understood as a chronicle of the actions of white men. Despite the work of pioneering historians like W.E.B. DuBois, George W. Williams, Herbert Aptheker, Bell Irwin Wiley, Benjamin Quarles, and others, there was little public awareness of the active role that African Americans had played in the Civil War. During the 1960s ethnic minorities, feminists, and liberal historians challenged American structures of power in both social and scholarly domains. The ferment of social change produced radical new interpretations of the past, along with new critiques of the "traditional" values upheld in older versions of American history.

The most striking difference between black and white reenactors can be seen in their responses to this "new" history. For blacks, recent

trends in the writing of history have meant the recovery or discovery of a past that had been largely lost to them. As one Fifty-fourth Massachusetts reenactor recalled, "When I went to school I was never taught any black history, any whatsoever. That was quite a few years ago; I am 51 now. I think a lot of it was recorded but it was swept away someplace after it was recorded. That is the way this country has always been." Other black reenactors' statements echo this sense of rediscovery and a feeling of mission—even obligation—about reclaiming their lost history. "There is a whole segment of our ancestors, coming out of slavery, that is totally missing," one man said. Another added, "I don't think that the real men got their due. Thanks to the reenactors they have risen the awareness of black participation in the Civil War. Within the last ten years there has been a proliferation of books on this subject. Before this you could hardly find anything. We are bringing to the forefront the accomplishments, the achievements of these men that have gone largely unrecognized." Many black reenactors clearly sense the psychic costs of their unrecognized legacy. One woman stated, "We [African Americans] have a very low self-esteem already. Knowing who you are and having a foundation, knowing that you have a wonderful history, makes you a stronger person. It helps you identify and be proud of what your race can do." Another woman wondered, "How can you feel good about anything if you don't know your history? If you don't have a true history, you cannot have anything. We don't have a true history." Many black reenactors also recognize that these gaps in history have affected white Americans as well as blacks. As one man in a Fifty-fourth Massachusetts company remarked, "It is important . . . to know that blacks were not passive observers, all slaves waiting to be emancipated. This is an impression that most of the public have, both blacks and whites. . . . It is equally important when dealing with the public, when working with people of European descent or African descent to get that same message out. Although they may have a different perspective the message is the same and it is important."

White reenactors' response to the "new" history is more complex. If black reenactors see themselves as leading a charge to capture a lost heritage, many white reenactors believe they are fighting a rearguard action on the contested field of American history. This is not to imply that all white reenactors are overtly hostile to more inclusive versions of history, although some undoubtedly are. It is far more common to encounter white reenactors who accept or even applaud the inclusion of new voices in the historical record but who nonetheless cannot let go of older images of the past because those images played such an important role in the shaping of the reenactors' own ideals and identi-

ties. White reenactors possess a highly ambivalent attitude toward contemporary historical scholarship. They welcome the new insofar as it supports what they loved about the old: the heroism of the citizen-soldier; the unquestioned goodness of the nation; the virtues of self-reliance, capitalism, and democracy that they see illustrated in the traditional story of the American past. Tension arises, however, when newer versions of history contest those values, leaving their very truthfulness in doubt.

Some white reenactors respond to these vexed issues directly, usually by vehement denials that race was a central factor leading to the Civil War. Another strategy—one that may explain reenactors' fascination for the minutiae of historical presentation—is to move the whole subject of the war to a materially oriented, value-free framework, where the debate over hand- versus machine-sewn buttonholes becomes more important than that of right versus wrong. No matter how they feel about recent challenges to traditional visions of American history and values, many reenactors search for unassailable ways to express those visions, even if it means reducing historical discussion to microscopic levels of detail. As one white male reenactor expressed his desire for a value-free history, "I think that our systems try to apologize for what we've done and who we are and what made us what we are, instead of just saying, 'This is what happened, this is what they were thinking, may have been right or wrong, let's not make a judgment today on what they did.' If we want to teach ethics, that's another course. But to teach history, it's facts. . . . They try to take a slant on it now."

African American reenactors present no threat to the reenactment community's view of itself or of American history so long as they are depicting qualities such as gallantry, loyalty, martial decorum, and other "bedrock" values. But when black reenactors' presence or discourse brings questions of race and morality to the fore, they inevitably disturb a community that prefers to avoid such issues and interpretations. The general acceptance of black reenactors in the community suggests that those "bedrock" values are shared across race lines. But blacks also meet with occasional hostility, and certainly with widespread wariness, from their white counterparts. No matter how compatible they may be in many ways, they still represent moral and social dilemmas that most white reenactors have tried to expunge from their depictions of the Civil War.

Black reenactors sometimes exhibit their own ambivalence about the social shifts of the past half-century. Some blacks (particularly the few who have recently begun to portray Confederate soldiers) may themselves be looking for a history free of the troubling need to make

judgments about the moral meaning of slavery and the Civil War. In general, though, African American reenactors embrace these meanings, whereas white reenactors tend to avoid them. The "new history" offers blacks an ever-increasing sense of support and validation; for white reenactors, that sense of being fully supported by the historical record is more a fond memory than a reality. As Jim Cullen has suggested in his discussion of how white reenactors use the Civil War story to express traditional visions of American society, many seem to fear

that in this increasingly diverse society, events such as the Civil War (which so many European Americans hold near and dear to their hearts, and in which they have such personal, familial, or assimilationist interests) may become less relevant. In this light, reenacting becomes a ritual . . . by which a majoritarian United States reassures itself that it, too, has a past, and that that past is as dramatic, interesting, and important as the alternative, multicultural pasts that are increasingly competing with it. . . . [The] Civil War has become a banner around which millions can rally, a point of reference that can shore up a center that fears it may not hold.¹³

White reenactors, then, no matter how supportive they are of the ideal of inclusion, often feel that it is accomplished at the expense of the history they love. Blacks, meanwhile, sense that the *Philadelphia Inquirer's* prophecy after the exclusion of African American troops from the 1865 Grand Review is on the verge of fulfillment—"Their time will yet come."

Gender Identity and Reenacting

Despite the considerable number of women who participate in Civil War reenactment, the spirit of the community is essentially masculine. One female reenactor, content in her support role as a civilian, admitted, "It's a guys' thing . . . it's male-driven, it's male-dominated, it's male-oriented." It is over questions of gender identity that black and white reenactors, no matter what their other differences, most readily find common ground.

Of all the challenges to "traditional" American structures and values in recent decades, the challenge to definitions of masculinity is perhaps the one that Civil War reenactors feel most keenly. One reenactor explained part of the reenactment appeal by confessing that

the white Anglo-Saxon male of today really doesn't know what he's supposed to be. Society says one thing, families say another, the media says another, his significant other says another. I think a lot of the younger

guys, young to middle-aged guys, are just looking for a simpler day, to where they can go out and not feel guilty about, you know, being quote-unquote "a man." . . . One of the things that's missing in today's society is there are no codes of conduct. Do you hold the door open for a lady? Well, you take a risk when you do.

An ex-Marine, when asked how it felt when a contemporary woman refused a male's offer of protection or support, replied: "Doesn't matter: protect and defend you we will. And if you resent it we're profoundly confused and put off. . . . Refusing the proffered protection from a man is to partially emasculate him."

The reenactors quoted above are white. But it is clear that black male reenactors share with their white comrades an intense appreciation of the masculine camaraderie found in reenacting. "I think that reenacting is a male thing, not a black thing or a white thing," said one black member of a Fifty-fourth Massachusetts company. The idea of "being a man" runs through the comments of reenactors of both races. "Comradeship between the men is most important. That is the way it was back then, especially with the black soldiers," remarked another Fifty-fourth Massachusetts reenactor. Speaking of Civil War soldiers in general, a white reenactor felt that "[to enlist] was what was right, and to be a man that's what you did, and you did it and that was that." The same individual explained his own military service by saying, "There's pride and there's duty, and I served my time, and my father did, and his father did, and my mother's father did, and it just goes right down the line." A black combat veteran explicitly connected his own military service with his identification with Civil War soldiers: "By the time you get to boot camp and once you're in the Marines for a while, you have this built-in pride and this built-in idea of respect for other Marines, and you love being with other Marines. . . . And I can kind of relate that back to the 54th because they had a common bond, a common respect."

For many adult male reenactors, mentoring younger men is an adjunct to the idea of "being a man." Those who see military or paramilitary experiences as valuable rites of passage take their roles as mentors and advisers to younger reenactors with utmost seriousness. "Kids today need somebody to look up to, somebody who is a hero in your life," one black Fifty-fourth Massachusetts reenactor commented, adding that Civil War soldiers could provide those heroes. And many adult male reenactors also see themselves, if not as heroes, then at least as models who may help to point a young man in the right direction.

Just as men and women of post-World War II generations are caught



Encampment of black troops at the Boston Esplanade during the Centennial Celebration of the monument to Shaw and the Fifty-fourth, 1997.
Courtesy National Park Service.

between older and newer definitions of American identity, men of these same generations are uneasy about changing definitions of manhood. Many white males feel strongly that they are being made to shoulder blame for everything now perceived as wrong in American history. But black men, too, especially those who identify strongly with military roles and models, may have similar difficulties in absorbing the effect of feminism in public and private life. Both black and white male reenactors find relief in being able—if only on occasional weekends—to present themselves as soldiers, patriots, rebels, protectors, or gentle men without having to worry who may be offended. An unapologetic masculinity is central to Civil War reenactment.

A comparison of the reception of African Americans within the reenactment community and reenactors' response to women who choose roles as disguised Civil War soldiers best illustrates the centrality of masculinity to historical reenactment. White reenactors may resist attempts to make race central to the story of the Civil War, but there has been no overt challenge to blacks' right to take the field. Despite hearing occasional hostile remarks masked as "authentic" nineteenth

century speech, "most of what I have experienced has been positive," one member of a black unit affirmed. "We have been respected."

By contrast, women who choose combat roles have provoked a heated, decade-long debate—punctuated by occasional lawsuits—that is far from resolved. Many female reenactors do take the field in uniform, with varying degrees of credibility, but their presence can be a very sore point with men who resent the invasion of one of the last male refuges. "When women are present, the differences are subtle but there nonetheless," wrote a columnist for *Camp Chase Gazette*, Civil War reenacting's monthly magazine. "It puts a finger smear onto our window into the past."¹⁴ White reenactors who may be uncomfortable or hostile about sharing a camp with blacks are clearly reluctant to say so publicly, but there has been no such reluctance in airing opinions about women in the ranks.

A black woman who put forward the idea of wearing a uniform within a company of the Fifty-fourth Massachusetts quickly discovered how jealously male reenactors guard the soldier role for themselves. "I wanted to be a soldier," she said. "I wanted to tote a gun. And they were really freaking out! . . . I wanted to play that role, because I'm a tomboy at heart, and I'm very comfortable in that role. And they're like, 'Oh, no, no, no, no, no!'" This woman eventually found a less controversial place for herself as a civilian reenactor. In this role, she and her female comrades now find that "We're not a threat. And that's what [the men in the unit] say to us, that we've added to them, we've brought attention to them, recognition to them, by doing our own separate thing and not competing, not wanting to be them. . . . We complement them. We're not trying to take over their roles."

If some social changes of the past fifty years divide black and white reenactors, others—particularly those involving gender—seem to unify the races. (Indeed, some female reenactors also seek relief from the confusion of shifting modern gender roles. Women, like men, often describe reenacting as a way to step temporarily into more clearly defined patterns of social behavior.) Those who initiated Civil War reenactment in the early 1960s were, perhaps, able to be more straightforward in their presentation of "traditional" roles and values. Or perhaps even then the stirrings of change prompted many men to find refuge in performed versions of American history and masculinity. By the time "baby boomers" began to reenact in the 1970s and 1980s, tension over cultural definitions of gender had become a fact of everyday life. Some Civil War reenactors successfully negotiate this tension in their "real" lives. For others, it is more problematic. But it seems fair to say that

virtually all, black and white, feel a sense of connection to traditional definitions of masculinity and share a need to incorporate those definitions—at least symbolically—into their images of themselves.

Military Service

Perceptions of history most vividly divide black and white reenactors, and expressions of gender identity most strikingly unite them, but the subject of military service generates both unity and division and is, perhaps, more typical of the unresolved state of American race relations.

Both black and white reenactors enter into Civil War reenactment's military atmosphere and the idealization of the American citizen-soldier. Many reenactors of both races are children of World War II veterans; they are saddened by the dissonance between their early positive images of the American soldier and their own coming of age during the Vietnam era. Most male reenactors entered young adulthood willing to go to war if their country called them, only to find their sense of duty deeply shaken during the 1960s and 1970s. Many found ways to avoid military service, and even those who did serve could not maintain unambivalent patriotism in the face of the troubling realities of the Vietnam War. One black Marine Corps veteran, who now reenacts as a member of the Fifty-fourth Massachusetts, revealed that, at least initially, "I felt strongly that if we were [in Vietnam], there was a reason for us to be there." In hindsight, though, he believes, "we should either have went in there and fought the war the way we know how to fight a war or we should not have been in it at all. And I lean more toward maybe we should not have been in it at all."

For these baby boomers, reenacting the Civil War provides a positive vicarious experience of war and military service. It is one that gives reenactors connections to comrades and country of the kind that their fathers' generation had during World War II, without the soul-searching that accompanied the nation's foray into Southeast Asia. The idea that reenactment rehabilitates or substitutes for real-life military experience can be heard in both general and specific comments from reenactors. One black member of a Fifty-fourth Massachusetts company addressed the relationship between Vietnam and Civil War reenactment.

You know, a lot of the guys in the [reenacted] 54th were in the service, but the Civil War thing really, like, woke them up. See, a lot of them didn't believe in the Vietnam era type thing—now they don't, anyway. But the Civil War thing, once they touch bases with it, it glues them to it and they just can't stop. . . . And I don't understand what that means, but I just think the Civil War has much more, something going for the

people, in my opinion, than Vietnam. Because Vietnam I think was somebody else's war.

Reenactors frequently draw the parallel between their hobby and the experience of real military service. "The camaraderie that you find in the real military, the closest I've come to finding it in the outside world is in reenacting, without a doubt," said an ex-military man who commands a Confederate unit. One young woman who had served with the Air Force agreed: "After six years in the military I find the atmosphere very, very similar. It has nothing to do with the fact that they're doing military roles. It has a lot to do with the fact that you all go out there and you suffer together." In this light, the heavy wool clothing, physical labor, and occasional foul weather that make up a large part of a reenacting weekend can be seen—as the actual military is seen by many—as a test of character and resourcefulness leading to strong bonds among those who share in it.¹⁵ Instead of taking place in the context of an ambiguous foreign intervention, Civil War reenactment offers an idealized, home-grown struggle. In it reenactors can find American courage and gallantry on both sides, set in a danger-free context and framed by a narrative made comfortingly clear by nearly a century and a half of hindsight.

For many blacks and whites, reenactment is a substitute for the "good war" they grew up believing it would someday be their duty to take part in. Reenactment offers a chance for a reaffirmation of the citizen-soldier role and a way to combine that role with other elements of identity based on race, gender, regionalism, or ideology. For some, reenactment functions as a kind of symbolic veterans association, providing an outlet for stories and emotions that are difficult to share elsewhere. One black combat veteran, seriously wounded in Vietnam nearly thirty years ago, confessed:

I never talked about the war when I got home. I wouldn't even talk to my kids when they asked me questions. . . . Only recently did I start talking about what went on in Vietnam. One night around the fire at a Civil War event with the 54th, we were talking about what went on during the day. . . . Before I knew it, I was drawing a connection to when I was in the service and I was telling the men, young and old, what had happened. They wanted to hear my story and I knew these guys, so the stuff that I held onto for so long came out.

In many ways, both idealism and disillusionment about military service can act as powerful bonds between black and white reenactors. But there are additional layers to black experiences in the American military that make the subject more complex. As the saga of the Fifty-

fourth Massachusetts illustrates so clearly, blacks, like other ethnic minorities in the United States, have historically used military service as a means to gain full citizenship. That their efforts have not always been successful, and that racism persists despite their sacrifices, makes these soldiers more viscerally aware of the shortcomings in the system they are being asked to defend with their lives.

During the Vietnam era, those shortcomings were highlighted by antiwar activists and others who focused on American racism at home and abroad. Not only were blacks underrepresented in American public life, these critics pointed out, but they were also overrepresented among the soldiers sent into combat. And once overseas, those soldiers had to grapple with questions of ethnic alliances no less troubling than those they had left at home. One black Civil War reenactor and combat veteran remembered, "When I was in Vietnam and we would come into a village, the dark-skinned Vietnamese would come up to me and other black soldiers and point to his skin and then to mine and say, 'Lookie, lookie, same, same.'" Black American soldiers traditionally have had to fight the additional enemy of American racism, and it is this that lends a unique quality to black reenactors' portrayal of Civil War soldiers. Black baby boomers, like black Civil War soldiers, know how it feels to be caught between the desire to participate fully in traditions of manhood and the awareness that American structures of power have been arrayed against them. When they become "glued" to the subject of the Civil War, they pay homage to pioneers in an unfinished struggle, an element missing from white reenactors' depictions of the war.¹⁶

FROM THE 1865 Grand Review in Washington to the 1989 filming of *Glory*—and the subsequent decade of black participation in Civil War reenactment—enormous changes have occurred in the nation's perception of the black role in the Civil War. In Civil War-related public commemorations and historical reenactments, exclusion and ridicule are no longer the rule. As one woman in a Fifty-fourth Massachusetts reenactor group concluded, "We have now come to a point where we are comfortable with saying, 'Your ancestor was a slave holder and mine was a slave.' That's okay. We can accept that today. We now can talk openly about these things, where before we couldn't. We have gained a kind of comfort level." More complex, however, is the question of how this comfort level has been achieved. Black participation and acceptance into the world of Civil War reenactment has not been a simple linear move. Many lines of identity continue to be crossed and recrossed to create the place that African American reenactors occupy in this once all-white and still conservative community.



Members of Companies A and B, Fifty-fourth Massachusetts Regiment, at the monument to Shaw and the Fifty-fourth, 1997. Courtesy National Park Service.

Like all cultural performances, Civil War reenactment both reflects and negotiates the society's social struggles. When we consider the life experiences of contemporary reenactors, black and white, clearly their depiction of the Civil War is a response to World War II, Vietnam, and other contemporary social transformations that have shaped their lives. This response leads in two divergent directions. Disillusioned by Vietnam and recalling the patriotic certainties of their childhoods, reenactors remain in search of the "good war," with its intense camaraderie and unambiguous righteousness. At the same time, only the most determined escapists among them can block out the awareness that America never has been as moral as they all once believed. Through performance—a medium ideally suited to the acting out of paradox and multiple realities—reenactors search for heroes and certainties in a culture that has come to admit the limitations of both.

African American reenactors share these nostalgic needs with whites and find common ground in a personal quest for moral certainty in the past. Like their white counterparts, they use reenactment as a respite from the many complexities of modern life. Both white and black reenactors celebrate the citizen-soldier tradition, search for personal and family "roots" in the story of the Civil War, and share the camaraderie

achieved through camping and performance. The "male bonding" within this hypermasculine, paramilitary environment often creates alliances that cross race lines. Ironically, it is a common ambivalence about social change—the effects of feminism or rapidly changing technology in everyday life—that helped make the racial integration of this largely white, conservative community possible.

But the African American presence in that community also raises unwelcome questions about the meaning of the Civil War and American definitions of freedom. What can we conclude from the fact that despite the tension caused by those questions, black reenactors generally have been accepted and respected by their white counterparts? First, for the majority of black and white reenactors, the need to discover and embody a heroic, "true" history may be stronger than the need to resolve vexed questions about race. In other words, within the community race is reduced to just one of many related factors that motivate reenactors. Second, the acceptance of black Civil War reenactors reflects a level of awareness among white reenactors—an awareness shaped during their youths in the 1960s and 70s—that no matter how one may wish it otherwise, no depiction of America can be complete without including those voices that challenge received accounts of the past. African American reenactors, then, serve as a conscience for the community, sometimes welcomed, sometimes resisted, but always in ways that resonate on some level with the white majority.

Civil War reenactment helps to facilitate a popular recasting and reintegration of the past in several important ways. The story of the Civil War itself is rich in the history of the struggle for racial equality. But for those who do not see race as central to the conflict, the story also offers ways to celebrate the valor of the American citizen-soldier, a figure honored by blacks and whites. Even reenactors who disagree about the meaning of the war can find themselves portraying it together. Through this medium, African Americans become contributors to a well-loved story and in the process gain a hearing for their demands for social justice. The inclusion of blacks in the Civil War reenactment community over the past decade not only has created a more accurate popular view of the Civil War but also has stimulated a reassessment of personal and national identity that will play an important part in the reenvisioning of America in the century to come.

Quarles himself, see Thomas Cripps, "A Certain Style: Benjamin Quarles and the Scholarship of the Center," *Maryland Historical Magazine* 93 (fall 1998): 289-300.

15. Selznick to Howard, January 6, 1937, in Rudy Behlmer, ed., *Memo from David O. Selznick* (New York: Viking Press, 1972), 151; discussed in Cripps, *Making Movies Black*, chap. 1.

16. Interview between Moss and Cripps, cited in Cripps, *Making Movies Black*, chap. 4; Agee quoted in Cripps, *Making Movies Black*, 112.

17. See Robert Burgoyne, *Film Nation: Hollywood Looks at U.S. History* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1997), 16-37, for a thorough analysis of the representation of racial identity in *Glory*.

18. Here is Douglass's scene, if he is to have one, but he is played as a thoughtful sage rather than at the height of his powers.

19. The still definitive account of this eventually vacated social experiment is Willie Lee Rose, *Rehearsal for Reconstruction: The Port Royal Experiment* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1964).

20. Walter Benjamin, "The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction," in Hannah Arendt, ed., *Illuminations*, trans. Harry Zohn (New York: Harcourt, Brace, and World, 1968), 222, 225. On Frederick Hart, see Tom Wolfe, "The Artist the Art World Couldn't See," *New York Times Magazine*, January 2, 2000, 16-19.

The African American Presence in Civil War Reenactment, by Cathy Stanton and Stephen Belyea

1. It is perhaps worthwhile here to clarify our approach to the use of reenactors as sources of information for this paper. The description of the 1997 encampment and parade was written from the perspective of Stephen Belyea, who participated in the centennial event in the role of military commander. He also interviewed fellow reenactors in two companies of the Fifty-fourth Massachusetts in 1998. Cathy Stanton conducted interviews with both black and white reenactors during 1996-98 as part of a two-year ethnographic fieldwork project. All interview sessions were taped and transcribed; tapes and transcriptions are in the possession of the authors. Because this study was informed by the discipline of anthropology, we have chosen to follow anthropological conventions and quote interview sources anonymously. We were less concerned with confidentiality and analyzing individual experiences within the reenactment community than with our purpose of examining a generalized experience of African Americans in Civil War reenactor culture. We recognize that there is a wide range of beliefs and practices among reenactors; our use of anonymous sources is not intended to suggest that one reenactor can possibly speak for all. But insofar as there are clearly identifiable patterns of belief and practice within the reenactor community, we have chosen interview material that speaks for those patterns. For a similar rationale of anonymously quoted interview material, see Richard Handler and Eric Gable, *The New History in*

an Old Museum: Creating the Past at Colonial Williamsburg (Durham, N.C.: Duke University Press, 1997), 26-27.

2. See Roger Abrahams, "Toward an Enactment-Centered Theory of Folklore," in William Bascom, ed., *Frontiers in Folklore* (Boulder, Colo.: Westview Press, 1977); John J. MacAloon, "Cultural Performances, Culture Theory," in John J. MacAloon, ed., *Rite, Drama, Festival, Spectacle: Rehearsals toward a Theory of Cultural Performance* (Philadelphia: Institute for the Study of Human Issues, 1984); Victor Turner, *Dramas, Fields, and Metaphors: Symbolic Action in Human Society* (Ithaca, N.Y.: Cornell University Press, 1974); and Victor Turner, *From Ritual to Theatre: The Human Seriousness of Play* (New York: Performing Arts Journal Publications, 1982).

3. Stuart McConnell, *Glorious Contentment: The Grand Army of the Republic* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1992), 8-9.

4. McConnell, *Glorious Contentment*, 213.

5. National encampments were large-scale annual reunions at which veterans camped together in brief, idealized versions of Civil War camps, remarkably similar to contemporary Civil War reenactments. Confederate veterans held comparable reunions each year. McConnell, *Glorious Contentment*, 217.

6. David Glassberg, *American Historical Pageantry: The Uses of Tradition in the Early Twentieth Century* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1990), 63.

7. Glassberg, *American Historical Pageantry*, 197.

8. Glassberg, *American Historical Pageantry*, 132.

9. Michael Kammen, *Mystic Chords of Memory: The Transformation of Tradition in American Culture* (New York: Knopf, 1991), 535.

10. The Civil War reenactor community in the United States is essentially a loose affiliation of independent small groups. In many cases the individual groups join to form brigade or battalion structures in order to facilitate large-scale military maneuvers, but reenactors' primary loyalties tend to be with their own units. Standards of authenticity are constantly debated within the reenactor community, although "authenticity" is frequently an issue through which more contemporary or personal concerns are negotiated. The general consensus of the community is that "nonperiod" items must be hidden from view whenever camps are open to spectators and should be used sparingly during nonpublic hours, in order to help create a more convincing illusion of the past for everyone in camp.

Estimates of the total number of Civil War reenactors have ranged from Jim Cullen's estimate of 20,000 to reenactor estimates of 40,000. A 1998 "mega-event" in Gettysburg attracted more than 20,000 participants. Jim Cullen, *The Civil War in Popular Culture: A Reusable Past* (Washington, D.C.: Smithsonian Institution Press, 1995), 186. For discussions of the development of contemporary reenactment, see Jay Anderson, *Time Machines: The World of Living History* (Nashville: American Association for State and Local History, 1984); R. Lee Hadden, *Reliving the Civil War* (Mechanicsburg, Pa.: Stackpole Books, 1996); and Cullen, *Civil War in Popular Culture*. Other information in

this section is drawn from personal observation and conversations with long-time reenactors.

11. Company A was the “camera” company, comprised of professional actors rather than amateur reenactors. Company B consisted of experienced reenactors and new recruits who intended to use their experience on the film as a starting point for future involvement with reenactment. In lieu of pay, many negotiated to keep the uniforms and equipment supplied by the film company. Company B remains an active reenactment unit of the Fifty-fourth Massachusetts in the Washington, D.C., area. Company D was formed largely of unemployed men from Savannah, Georgia, and Jacksonville, Florida (including some from Jacksonville drug rehabilitation programs). This group was used for “deep background” and was issued inauthentic equipment. Company I consisted of active-duty soldiers from a nearby military base. According to a participant, these men “required very little training or supervision to turn them into convincing members of the 54th Massachusetts.” David Jurgella, “One Week of ‘Glory.’” *Military History Illustrated, Past and Present* 26 (July 1990): 18.

12. Only by accident, as during the retreat at the Battle of Olustee, Florida, were soldiers in black and white regiments thrown together during combat.

13. Cullen, *Civil War in Popular Culture*, 199.

14. Jonah Begone, “The Vandals at the Gates,” *Camp Chase Gazette*, May 1998, 56–57.

15. The officer in charge of Company D during the filming of *Glory* related how the shared experiences of the ill-equipped “deep background” extras, who were excluded from other units’ camaraderie, eventually coalesced into a feeling of group unity and pride among themselves. The men asked to be taught the drill and tactics that were already familiar to the reenactors. “At the end of the week, before heading out to the beach for the final night’s filming, I thanked ‘Co. D’ for their efforts and told them I was proud to have been associated with the film, and with them. They responded with ‘three cheers for the Captain’ and marched over the boardwalk with feet stamping in time to a chant of ‘Company D, Company D.’” Jurgella, “One Week of ‘Glory,’” 20.

16. There are other instances of reenactors’ viewing their performances in similar ways. For example, some female reenactors who choose soldier roles see themselves as recovering the memory of pioneers in the field of gender equality. Hispanics, Jews, and other ethnic minorities sometimes celebrate their forebears’ efforts to gain greater acceptance in American society, much as blacks do. Southern nationalists may use reenactment to promote the idea of regional independence. We are talking here about paying homage to cultural pioneers, which may be quite different from historical revisionism. In general, however, this spirit of paying homage to pioneers in an unfinished struggle is much more typical of black reenactors than of whites.